

Political Theory Exam  
January 2026

Please answer one question from each of the following three sections. The first section is meant to focus on the history of political thought, the second on more recent theorizing, and the third on topics related to your personalized lists.

Each answer should have a clear thesis argument and should be based on analysis of the relevant texts. You have seven hours to complete the exam.

The examination will be judged as a whole; avoid repetition.

Section 1

1. Plato's *Republic* is a dialogue about justice. What does Plato mean to convey about justice, and how does the dialogic form of the work help him convey it?
2. Like Aristotle, Tocqueville considers aristocracy and democracy as distinct political regimes. Unlike Aristotle, he regards the idea of a "mixed regime" as a "chimera." Explain why Tocqueville departs from Aristotle on this point, and what the difference tells us about the ways in which Tocqueville's approach to politics is and is not Aristotelian.
3. Was Rousseau a friend of the Enlightenment or a critic?

Section 2

1. Discuss any two debates among political theorists that could benefit from paying attention to Benedict Anderson's *Imagined Communities*?
2. What, if anything, is democratic about the electoral competition for power in modern states? Consider Robert Dahl, Bernard Manin, W.E.B. Du Bois and at least one other thinker.
3. What are the strengths and weaknesses of understanding justice through the lens of social contract theories? Consider at least three of these thinkers: John Rawls, Charles Mills, Carol Pateman, Iris Young.

Section 3

1. Have political theorists succeeded in resolving the apparent tension between democracy and representation?
2. What are the strengths and weaknesses of understanding freedom as "non-domination"?
3. What is the most difficult challenge that theorists of equality must face in elaborating a coherent and compelling theory? How have they faced it, or avoided doing so?